

Narrative Crossroads

Character Analysis Through Roleplaying for Literary and Historical Study

Solo System Reference Document (Solo SRD)

An SRD is the reusable core of a game's rules, published under a license that lets anyone build on it. This one covers the solo system only: the three lenses, the round, the Character Frame, and how to build your own module. The literary modules are content built on this system, not part of it.

Solo here is the tabletop sense: each student plays alone, all at once, and the class discussion afterward is the other half of the method.

A group version of Narrative Crossroads is in development and will be released under a different license.

This document introduces Narrative Crossroads, a solo journaling game — played by everyone at once — designed to help students analyze literary characters and historical figures. A student inhabits a character at a threshold moment, takes one of three lenses, and writes a few sentences in character. The class then pools its readings, and that discussion is the analysis. The writing is the play.

System Overview

The Narrative Crossroads solo system engages students in character analysis through five integrated components:

1. Character Selection
2. Threshold Moment Exploration
3. Taking a Lens
4. Writing in Character
5. Harvest and Analysis

Nothing is rolled against a character. A die appears only to spread a room across the three lenses, and it can be replaced by simply choosing. There is nothing to succeed or fail at, which is what makes the method work for reluctant readers and multilingual learners: the only thing being judged is whether the text supports what you wrote.

Key Components in Detail

1. Character Selection

Students select a character from the text they're studying, or roll a die for one. Each character comes with textual evidence rather than statistics — what they want, and what they fear, each supported by a line or page number.

What a character wants and fears reflects who the character *is* in the text, not who students want them to be.

Example Characters

Character	What they want	What they fear
Rainsford	To survive, and to stay the kind of man he believes he is	Becoming the animal he has always hunted
Zaroff	A quarry that can reason — a hunt worth having	Boredom, and being ordinary

2. Threshold Moment Exploration

Students explore characters at threshold moments—critical turning points in the narrative where the character could genuinely have chosen otherwise. The whole room works the same moment, so the readings are comparable.

Example Threshold Moment

Threshold Moment	Why it is a threshold
Discovering Zaroff hunts humans	Rainsford has understood something he cannot un-understand, and every option left to him is bad

3. Taking a Lens

Each student reads the moment through one of three lenses. They pick, or roll a die so the room spreads across all three:

Roll	Lens	What it asks
1–2	Confrontation	A clash. What are you up against, and what does facing it cost?
3–4	Comprehension	A realization. What do you understand now that you didn't a moment ago?
5–6	Connection	The bonds. Who is this really about, and what do you owe them?

The lenses are three ways of reading one moment. They are not skills, stats, or abilities, and nothing is ever rolled against them. The die only seeds: it decides which way in a student gets, never how anything turns out.

4. Writing in Character

Students write a few sentences in the character's voice, at that moment, showing one thing from what the character wants or fears.

The writing is the play — not a record of play that happened somewhere else. Everyone writes at once, so nobody waits for a turn and nobody is on the spot.

5. Harvest and Analysis

- Several responses are read aloud, at least one from each lens
- The class asks: *which reading does the text support, and what's your evidence?*
- Students connect their readings to broader themes and character development

- Students consider how the moment would read through a lens they didn't take
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Implementation Guide

Materials Needed

- A die, if you want to assign lenses by chance rather than choice. It is optional, and a dice-rolling app works equally well.
- Character Frame cards
- Module sheets with characters and threshold moments
- Student journals, or the back of the card, for longer responses

Class Session Structure (45–60 minutes)

1. **Introduction (5 min):** Explain the round and distribute materials
2. **Character Selection (5 min):** Students choose a character, or roll a die for one
3. **Threshold Moment (5 min):** The teacher frames one moment for the whole room
4. **Evidence (10 min):** Students record what the character wants and fears, with a line or page number
5. **Take a Lens and Write (15–20 min):** Students take a lens and write in character
6. **Harvest (10–15 min):** Read several aloud, at least one per lens, then ask which reading the text supports

Accommodations for Multilingual Learners

- Sentence frames for the written response
 - Visual character cards showing what the character wants and fears
 - Pre-teaching vocabulary in threshold moments
 - Partner options for collaborative analysis
 - Audio recording alternatives to written responses
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Assessment Options

- **Character Journals:** Written responses in the character's voice
 - **Audio Character Studies:** Written responses read aloud in character
 - **Alternative Readings:** The same moment written through a different lens
 - **Comparative Analyses:** Contrasting character motivations
 - **Thematic Connections:** Linking character decisions to text themes
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Theoretical Foundation

Narrative Crossroads draws from several educational and gaming approaches:

1. **Reader Response Theory** — Focuses on the reader's interaction with text
2. **Role-Playing Pedagogy** — Uses perspective-taking to deepen understanding

3. **Threshold Concept Theory** — Examines transformative moments in learning

4. **Game-Based Learning** — Employs structured play for analytical purposes

The framework creates a “cognitive apprenticeship” where students externalize their thinking about character motivation through structured roleplay.

Aligning with ELA Standards

Narrative Crossroads addresses numerous Michigan ELA standards across grade levels.

Reading Literature

- **RL.9-10.2** — Determine a theme and analyze in detail its development
- **RL.9-10.3** — Analyze how complex characters develop, interact with other characters, and advance the plot
- **RL.9-10.5** — Analyze how an author’s choices concerning structure create effects such as tension or surprise

Writing

- **W.9-10.1.B** — Develop claims and counterclaims fairly, supplying evidence
- **W.9-10.3** — Write narratives to develop real or imagined experiences
- **W.9-10.3.D** — Use precise words, telling details, and sensory language

Speaking and Listening

- **SL.9-10.1** — Initiate and participate effectively in collaborative discussions
 - **SL.9-10.4** — Present information, findings, and supporting evidence clearly
 - **SL.9-10.6** — Adapt speech to a variety of contexts and tasks
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Customizing for Different Texts

Literary Applications

- **Short Stories:** Focus on key decision moments in compact narratives
- **Novels:** Explore character development across multiple thresholds
- **Drama:** Examine dramatic choices at pivotal scenes
- **Poetry:** Analyze personas and voices in narrative poems

Historical Applications

- **Biographical Study:** Explore historical figures at decisive moments
 - **Social Movements:** Examine participant choices during key events
 - **Cultural Transitions:** Analyze decisions during periods of change
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Sample Play Reference

Character: Rainsford (“The Most Dangerous Game”) **Wants:** To survive, and to stay the kind of man he believes he is **Fears:** Becoming the animal he has always hunted **Threshold Moment:** Being hunted — when Rainsford must create a trap

Lens: Connection — *who is this really about, and what do you owe them?*

Sample Written Response

“I’ve always believed in fair chase—that hunting requires skill, preparation, and respect for your quarry. I’ve despised needless cruelty or those who hunt merely for the sake of killing. There must be purpose, whether for food, protection, or the genuine test of skill against a worthy adversary. I’ve lived by the hunter’s ethic that you don’t cause unnecessary suffering. That’s why Zaroff’s ‘sport’ disgusts me so profoundly—it violates every principle I hold. Yet now, as I set traps designed to maim or kill him, I wonder if survival supersedes all codes. Does my ethical stance change when I’m fighting for my life? I still believe in my principles, but I’m learning that morality looks different when you’re the one being hunted.”

Version 3

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